What Is Self-Attention

Contents

1. Overview 2
2. Prerequisites 3
3. Turning words into numbers 3
4. Static embeddings hold an average meaning 4
    4.1 The average, worked out 4
    4.2 The same effect in real text 5
5. Static and contextual embeddings 6
6. Self-attention: static in, contextual out 7
7. Summary 10
8. Sources 10
9. Key terms 11

Where this fits: Pipeline map step 5 (Engineer features). See the Course map.

0 Foundations	1 Frame	2 Get data	3 Understand	4 Clean	**5 Features**	6 Reduce
7 Split	8 Model	9 Evaluate	10 Tune	11 Deploy	12 Test	13 Monitor

- **Builds on:** Word embeddings; Meaning as direction in embedding space.
- **Leads to:** Self-attention (query, key, value).

1. Overview

Key point: A **word embedding** (G-2127) (a list of numbers, a **vector** (G-2081), that stands for a word) gives each word one fixed vector, learned from the average way the word is used. The word "bank" gets the same vector in "money bank grows" and in "river bank flows". **Self-attention** (G-1763) is a mechanism that takes the static embeddings of all the words of a sentence and returns new, **contextual embeddings** (G-462), in which each word's vector depends on the words around it.

Every **natural language processing** (G-1305; NLP) application, whether sentiment analysis, named entity recognition or machine translation, starts from words, and computers work with numbers. The first step is always to turn words into numbers. Word embeddings do this well, but they have one weakness: they are **static** (G-1877), the same in every sentence. Self-attention is the transformer's answer to that weakness, and it is the core of the transformer.

This Note explains **what** self-attention does and why it is needed. The idea of a word as a mix of its sentence explains **how** it works inside.

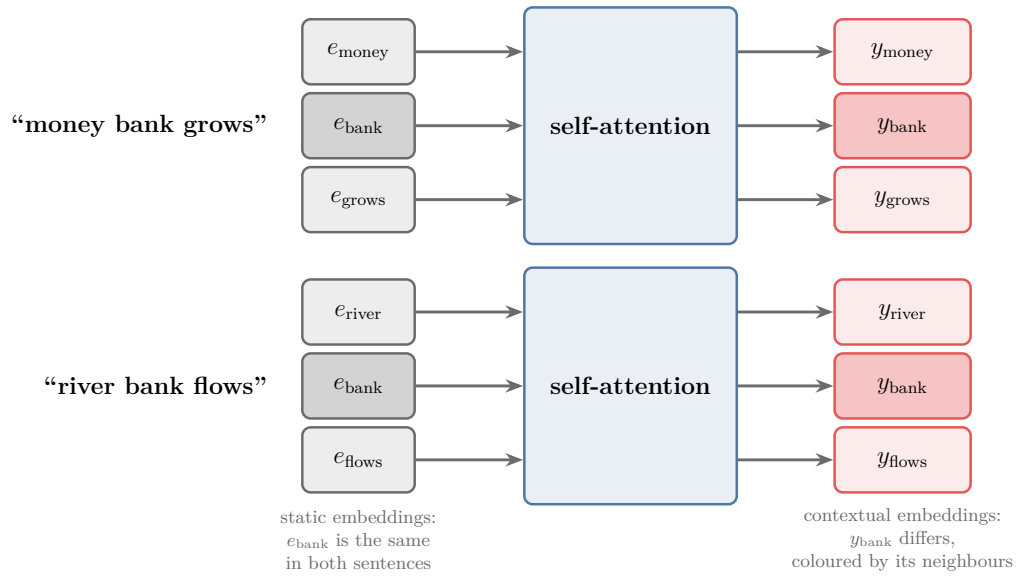


Figure 1: Self-attention as a box: the same static vector e_{bank} goes in for both sentences, but a different contextual vector y_{bank} comes out

2. Prerequisites

- How one-hot encoding works: a category as a **vector** (G-2081) of 0s with one 1.
- **Bag of words** (G-250): a text as a vector of word counts.
- **Word embeddings** (G-2127) and Keras' `Embedding` layer.
- **Cosine similarity** (G-491): how similar two vectors are.

3. Turning words into numbers

> **Key point:** One-hot encoding and bag of words turn words into numbers but carry no meaning. Word embeddings carry meaning: similar words get similar **vectors** (G-2081).

Turning text into numbers is called **vectorization** (G-2084). The early methods count words (Figure 2):

- **One-hot encoding** (G-1379) lists the **vocabulary** (G-2092; the distinct words) and writes each word as a vector with a 1 at its own place. For the vocabulary mat, cat, rat: mat is $[1, 0, 0]$, cat is $[0, 1, 0]$, rat is $[0, 0, 1]$. The sentence "mat cat mat" becomes $[1, 0, 0]$, $[0, 1, 0]$, $[1, 0, 0]$.
- **Bag of words** (G-250) counts how often each vocabulary word appears in a sentence: "mat cat mat" becomes $[2, 1, 0]$ (two mats, one cat, no rat) and "cat rat rat" becomes $[0, 1, 2]$.
- **TF-IDF** improves bag of words by weighting each count by how rare the word is across documents (SLP3 ch. 5).

(a) One-hot: "mat cat mat"

	mat	cat	rat
mat	1	0	0
cat	0	1	0
mat	1	0	0

one row per word, a single 1 in each

(b) Bag of words

	mat	cat	rat
"mat cat mat"	2	1	0
"cat rat rat"	0	1	2

one row of counts per sentence; the order of the words is lost

Neither says that two words are alike: the numbers carry no meaning.

Figure 2: The counting methods on the vocabulary mat, cat, rat. (a) One-hot: one row per word. (b) Bag of words: one row of counts per sentence

In Figure 2, each row is one vector and each column is one vocabulary word; each cell holds a number (0 when the word is absent; the cell is shaded when the number is not 0). Read across a row to see that word's (or sentence's) vector.

None of these says anything about meaning: in one-hot space, every pair of words is equally far apart. **Word embeddings** (G-2127) fix this (see **word embeddings** (G-2127)). A

neural network reads a large text collection, such as all of Wikipedia, sees how each word is used, and represents every word as a dense vector of n numbers, where n is typically 64, 256 or 512. Words used in similar ways get similar vectors.

A useful picture: each embedding is an arrow, and **each direction in the space is one aspect of meaning**, not each number. King and queen point in similar directions, and cricketer points elsewhere. The step from "man" to "woman" is roughly the same arrow as the step from "king" to "queen", so that arrow can be read as a direction for gender, and the **dot product** (G-634; multiply two vectors entry by entry and add, as in the example below; see computing the dot product) of a word's vector with it measures how much of that aspect the word carries (Sanderson 2024, Ch 5). The single numbers of an embedding have no labels and rarely a clean meaning of their own; the meaning lives in directions, which mix many numbers. A word is a point shows this on real word vectors. For this Note one fact is enough: similar words lie close together.

The dot product of the vectors $(1, 2)$ and $(3, 4)$, one step per line:

$$(1, 2) \cdot (3, 4) = 1 \times 3 + 2 \times 4$$

$$= 3 + 8 = 11$$

4. Static embeddings hold an average meaning

> **Key point:** An embedding is trained once on a whole corpus, so a word's **vector** (G-2081) reflects how the word is used **on average** in that corpus. Whatever the sentence, the word gets that one vector.

4.1 The average, worked out

> **Key point:** If "apple" is a fruit in 9 of 10 sentences, its **vector** (G-2081) leans 9 to 1 towards fruit.

Suppose we train embeddings with two dimensions, which we read as **taste** and **technology**. Sentences such as "an apple a day keeps the doctor away", "apple is healthy" and "apple is better than orange" pull the vector of "apple" towards taste; "apple makes great phones" pulls it towards technology.

1. **In words:** each use of the word pulls its vector towards the meaning of that use. The final vector is the average pull over the whole corpus. For example, 3 fruit sentences and 1 company sentence give the average pull:

$$\frac{3 \times (1, 0) + 1 \times (0, 1)}{4}$$

$$= (0.75,\ 0.25)$$

2. **Formula:** with n_f fruit sentences pulling towards $(1, 0)$ and n_c company sentences pulling towards $(0, 1)$,

$$e_{\text{apple}} = \frac{n_f\,(1,0) + n_c\,(0,1)}{n_f + n_c}$$

3. **Example:** corpus A has 9,000 fruit sentences and 1,000 company sentences:

$$e_{\text{apple}} = \frac{9000\,(1,0) + 1000\,(0,1)}{10000}$$

$$e_{\text{apple}} = (0.9,\ 0.1)$$

Corpus B, with the numbers swapped, gives $(0.1,\ 0.9)$ (Figure 3).

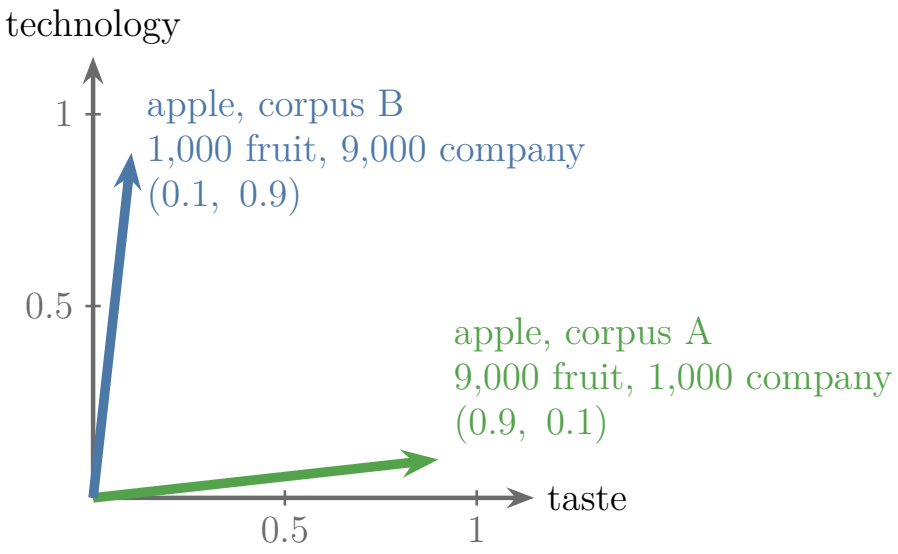


Figure 3: The same word gets a different static vector from a different corpus: its vector is the average meaning in that corpus

Figure 3 is one plane with taste on the horizontal axis and technology on the vertical axis. Each arrow is the vector of "apple" in one corpus: it leans towards taste in corpus A (green) and towards technology in corpus B (blue).

The formula is a simplification: real embedding methods do not literally average. But they are built from counts of which words appear near which, summed over every occurrence of the word (SLP3 ch. 5), so the vector is fixed by the mix of uses in the corpus.

4.2 The same effect in real text

> **Key point:** Embeddings learned from 116,830 real English sentences put "bank" next to shop and supermarket: in that text, a bank is always a building where money is kept.

The Notebook learns 50-number embeddings from the 116,830 distinct English sentences of the Keras English–French translation dataset. It counts which words appear within 4 words of each other and compresses the counts with the **singular value decomposition** (G-1813; SVD, a way to squeeze a big table of numbers into a few strong directions), the method of **latent semantic analysis** (G-1049) (see **latent semantic analysis** (G-1049)).

> **Extra:** The counts are first weighted by **positive pointwise mutual information** (G-1544; PPMI), which scores how much more often two words appear together than chance would give, and sets negative scores to 0. The SVD then keeps the 50 strongest directions. Word2vec, the best-known embedding method, can be seen as implicitly working with such a PPMI-weighted count matrix (Levy and Goldberg 2014, cited in SLP3 ch. 5).

The **nearest neighbours** (G-1306; the words whose vectors are closest) of a few words, by **cosine similarity** (G-491; a score from -1 to 1 for how closely two vectors point the same way: 1 means the same direction):

Word	Six nearest words
bank	shop, bookstore, supermarket, hall, convenience, hospital
river	lake, sea, across, flows, village, bridge
apple	pie, fruit, apples, baked, banana, orange
phone	telephone, cell, passport, address, number, card

"Bank" appears in 95 sentences of this corpus, and none of them mentions a river ("he works at a bank", "is there a bank near here?"). So its **static** (G-1877) vector is the money kind of bank: its cosine similarity is 0.40 with "money" and only 0.24 with "river". "Apple" is a fruit here, because the corpus never mentions the company.

5. Static and contextual embeddings

> **Key point:** A **static embedding** (G-1877) gives a word the same vector in every sentence. A **contextual embedding** changes the word's **vector** (G-2081) according to the other words of the sentence.

Static embeddings are trained once and then used again and again, in every sentence. That is the problem. Suppose we translate into Hindi the sentence

> "Apple launched a new phone while I was eating an orange."

With static embeddings, "apple" enters the translation model with its average vector, $(0.9, 0.1)$ in corpus A: a fruit. In this sentence, it is the company. What we want is an embedding that notices "launched" and "phone", raises the technology part and lowers the taste part. It should also not be misled by "orange", which belongs to a different part of the sentence.

The same holds for two shorter phrases, "money bank grows" and "river bank flows". The word "bank" means a financial institution in the first and the side of a river in the second,

but a static embedding gives it exactly the same vector in both. In the Notebook, Keras' `Embedding` layer, loaded with the embeddings of section 4.2, returns identical numbers for "bank" in the two phrases: an embedding layer is a **lookup table**, and the lookup ignores the neighbours (Figure 4).

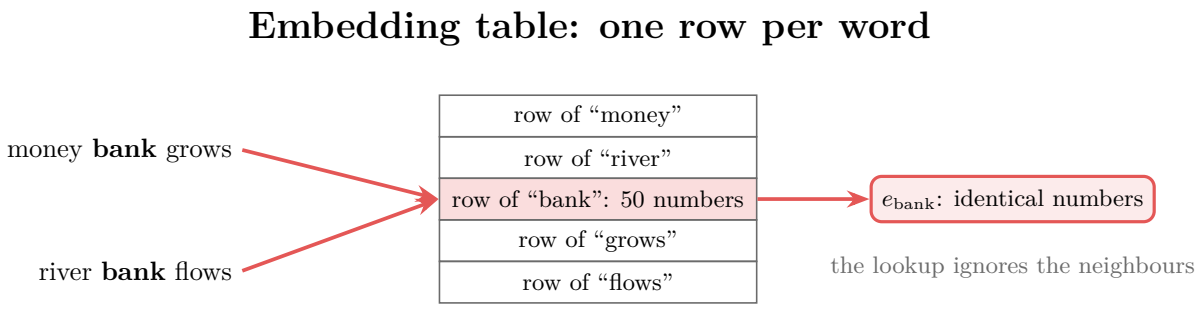


Figure 4: An embedding layer is a lookup table. In both phrases, "bank" picks the same row, so it gets the same 50 numbers whatever its neighbours

SLP3 (ch. 7) makes the same point: with static embeddings, a word's representation "is always the same vector irrespective of the context".

An embedding that changes with the sentence is a **contextual embedding** (SLP3 ch. 7).

6. Self-attention: static in, contextual out

> **Key point: Self-attention** (G-1763) is a function: the static embeddings of all the words of a sentence go in, one contextual embedding per word comes out. In the Notebook, "bank" moves towards "river" in "river bank flows" and towards "money" in "money bank grows".

Self-attention is a mechanism that turns **static embeddings** (G-1877) into contextual embeddings. Think of it as a box (Figure 1). The embeddings of all the words of a sentence go in together (e for an input embedding): $e_{\text{river}}, e_{\text{bank}}, e_{\text{flows}}$. Some calculations happen inside, and one new **vector** (G-2081) per word comes out (y for an output): $y_{\text{river}}, y_{\text{bank}}, y_{\text{flows}}$. Each output is a **contextual embedding**: it takes into account how the word is used in this sentence. The original paper describes self-attention as "an attention mechanism relating different positions of a single sequence in order to compute a representation of the sequence" (Vaswani et al. 2017, section 2). The transformer then uses these **contextual embeddings** (G-462) in its later layers.

The Notebook passes the two phrases through the simplest form of self-attention, the one the next Note builds from scratch, with the real embeddings of section 4.2. The **cosine similarity** (G-491) of the vector for "bank" with "money" and with "river":

Vector for “bank”	Similarity to “money”	Similarity to “river”
static, in any sentence	0.40	0.24
after self-attention, “money bank grows”	**0.68**	0.13
after self-attention, “river bank flows”	0.21	**0.71**

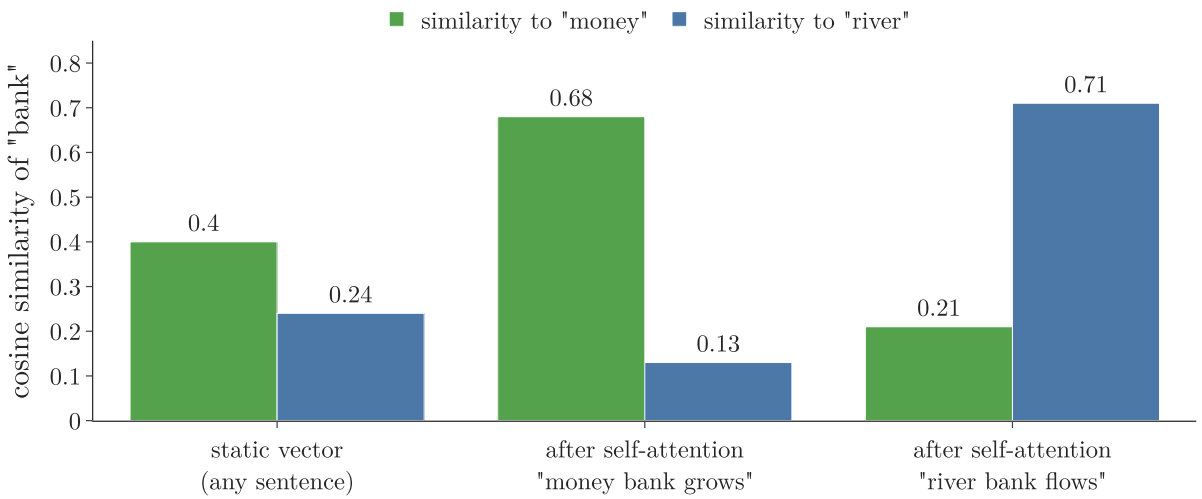


Figure 5: The table as bars. The static vector leans a little towards “money”. After self-attention, the same word leans strongly towards “money” in one phrase and towards “river” in the other

The static vector leans a little towards money, the average meaning of the corpus. After self-attention, the vector for “bank” in “river bank flows” is now much closer to “river” than to “money”, although the corpus never once used “bank” in that sense. The neighbours alone changed it.

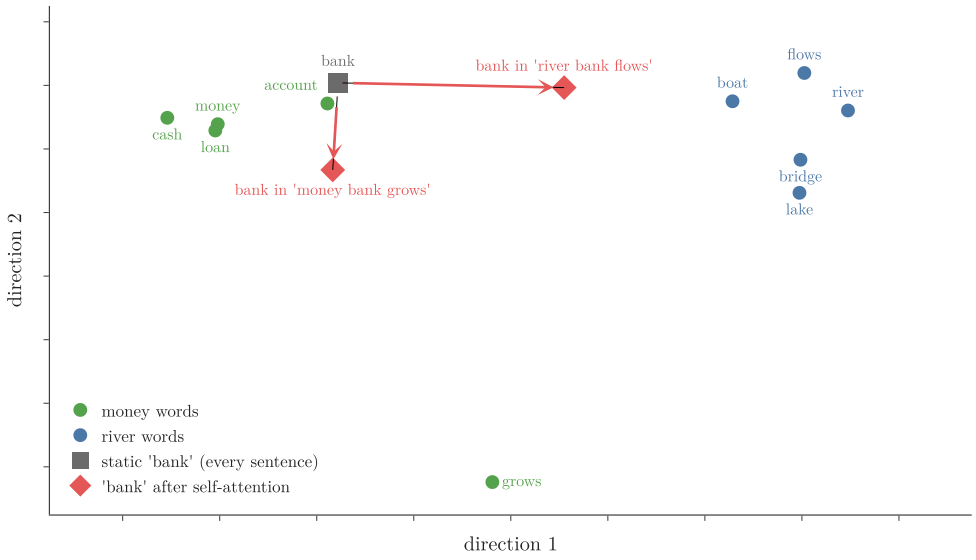


Figure 6: Real word vectors, flattened to 2-D. The static "bank" (grey square) sits with the money words. After self-attention (red diamonds), the "bank" of "river bank flows" has moved towards the river words; the "bank" of "money bank grows" stays on the money side and moves towards "grows"

Figure 6 shows the same thing on a map. The map keeps only 2 of the 50 directions, so distances on it are approximate; the table gives the exact similarities.

How the box computes its output, and how it learns to do so for a particular task, is the subject of the idea of a word as a mix of its sentence.

7. Summary

	Static embedding	Contextual embedding
Vector for a word	one, fixed after training	different in every sentence
Learned from	the average use of the word in the training corpus	the word **and** its neighbours in the current sentence
"bank" in "river bank flows"	the money meaning (similarity 0.24 to "river")	moved to the river meaning (0.71)
Produced by	an embedding (Word2Vec, GloVe, Keras `Embedding`)	self-attention

- Every NLP task starts by turning words into numbers, because computers work with numbers: one-hot, bag of words, TF-IDF, then **word embeddings** (G-2127), which capture meaning where the counting methods keep every pair of words equally far apart.
- A **static embedding** (G-1877) holds the average meaning of a word in its training corpus, because it is trained once over every use of the word and then looked up from a table that ignores the neighbours.
- A word with several meanings needs a **vector** (G-2081) that depends on the sentence: a contextual embedding, because otherwise "bank" in "river bank flows" keeps the money meaning.
- **Self-attention** (G-1763) takes the static embeddings of a sentence and returns contextual embeddings, one per word, so the neighbours alone can move "bank" to the river meaning (0.71 to "river").
- That is what self-attention is for: fixing the one weakness of word embeddings, that they are the same in every sentence.

8. Sources

Built from

- CampusX, "What is Self Attention | Transformers Part 2 | CampusX", YouTube, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=XnGGmvpDLA0
- Sanderson, G. (3Blue1Brown), "Transformers, the tech behind LLMs | Deep Learning Chapter 5", 2024, 3blue1brown.com/lessons/gpt, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wjZofJX0v4M. 13:33–17:44 (directions in embedding space carry meaning; woman − man ≈ queen − king; the dot product measures how much of a direction a vector has).

Other references

- Jurafsky, D. and Martin, J. H. *Speech and Language Processing*, 3rd ed. draft (19 August 2026), web.stanford.edu/~jurafsky/slp3. Chapter 5 (static embeddings; tf-idf; word2vec and PPMI, citing Levy and Goldberg 2014; SVD on word co-occurrence counts); chapter 7, section 7.1 (static embeddings are the same "irrespective of the context"; contextual embeddings; the "bank" of a river).

- Vaswani, A. et al. (2017). Attention Is All You Need. *NeurIPS 2017*. arXiv:1706.03762. Section 2 (definition of self-attention).
- Levy, O. and Goldberg, Y. (2014). Neural Word Embedding as Implicit Matrix Factorization. *NeurIPS 2014*. Cited in SLP3 ch. 5.
- Tatoeba (tatoeba.org) English–French sentence pairs, prepared by many-things.org/anki (file of 7 April 2019) and distributed for the Keras examples at storage.googleapis.com/download.tensorflow.org/data/fra-eng.zip. Licence CC BY 2.0.

9. Key terms

Terms taught in this Note come first; linked terms are recaps, taught in the Note the link opens.

Term	Meaning
Contextual embedding (G-462)	A vector for a word that changes with the other words of its sentence, so "bank" gets one vector in "river bank" and another in "money bank". Self-attention produces it.
Static embedding (G-1877)	An embedding that gives a word the same vector in every sentence, so "bank" gets one vector in both "money bank" and "river bank"; self-attention fixes this by making the vector depend on context.
PPMI (G-1544)	Positive pointwise mutual information: a score of how much more often two words appear together than by chance, with negative scores set to 0.
Average meaning (G-237)	What a static embedding stores: the word's meaning averaged over all its uses in the training corpus.
Word embedding (G-2127)	A learned real-valued vector for each word; words used in similar ways get nearby vectors.
Vector (G-2081)	A list of numbers: a 1D tensor.
Self-attention (intra-attention) (G-1763)	Attention in which the words of one sequence attend to each other (the queries, keys and values all come from that sequence); it gives each word a new vector that depends on the words around it.
Natural language processing (NLP) (G-1305)	The part of ML that works with human language.

Term	Meaning
Bag of words (G-250)	The simplest way to turn texts into feature vectors: list every unique word (the vocabulary), give each word one dimension, and count how often each word appears in the text.
Cosine similarity (G-491)	A score from -1 to 1 for how closely two vectors point the same way: the cosine of the angle between them. It ignores their lengths, so it compares texts or word embeddings by direction only.
Vectorization (of data) (G-2084)	Converting data such as text into vectors of numbers, because ML algorithms work only with numbers.
One-hot encoding (G-1379)	Replacing a nominal column by one 0/1 column per category, with a single 1 in each row; also used to represent words.
Vocabulary (V) (G-2092)	The list of distinct words (tokens) in a set of texts; in a translation model, those of the target language, with one output node per word.
Dot product (G-634)	Multiplying two vectors entry by entry and adding the products, $u^{\mathsf{T}}x$, which gives one number. It is large when the vectors point the same way, so it measures similarity and gives projections.
Singular value decomposition (SVD) (G-1813)	A way to write any matrix, square or not, as three simple steps: turn, stretch by the singular values, turn ($A = U\Sigma V^{\mathsf{T}}$: orthogonal, diagonal, orthogonal; a factorisation). ML uses it for PCA and to compress data.
Latent semantic analysis (LSA) (G-1049)	Describing each document by a few topic directions of the document-word matrix (its top k singular directions, found with the SVD), so that texts on one topic line up.
Nearest neighbours (neighbours) (G-1306)	The rows at the smallest distance from a given row; in KNN, the k training points closest to the query point.